

[Return to Search](#)


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Original Page: 177

Culture (OWC): [Lozi \(FQ09\)](#)

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Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Section Title(S)

KINSHIP STRUCTURE AND THE AFFILIATION OF CHILDREN

Behaviour to affines varies markedly according to generation. Parents-in-law and children-in-law, who address each other by a self-reciprocal term (*mukwenyani*), are treated with great respect. Son-in-law and mother-in-law, and father-in-law and daughter-in-law, practise mutual avoidance and if they touch each other must pay damages 'to wash away the fault'. They must not sit alone in a hut or use bad language before each other. A son-in-law should not sit on the same mat as his mother-in-law. This respect is not, however, carried as far as among the Zulu, where the daughter-in-law must avoid using any word like the names of her senior male relatives-in-law, and must not walk through the cattlekraal or the men's place.

606  
[Parents-In-Law And Children-In-Law](#)

Directly related brothers- and sisters-in-law behave freely to each other. They are 'man and wife', even when of the same sex, though they more often call each other *mulamu* than 'wife' and 'husband'. But they should not marry. They joke and tease each other. A spouse takes over from his or her partner behaviour patterns to grandparents, nieces, and nephews.

606  
[Parents-In-Law And Children-In-Law](#)

The corporate groups of kindred which in theory have lasted from the beginnings of Lozi history are the villages. Since people have constantly moved or been moved by the king between villages and neighbourhoods, the pattern of kinship links in local communities is constantly altering. No unilineal framework exists to which they can be referred; only royal people close to ruling kings can trace their descent from Mboo, the founder of the Lozi kingdom, son of God and His daughter. This agnatic line is the core of the whole nation's history. Nevertheless, for commoners, too, kinship links are all-

173  
[Traditional History](#)

565  
[Classes](#)

611  
[Rules Of Descent](#)

important in defining membership of a village and rights in it, and denoting relationships with and claims in other villages. Descent-names provide the ultimate reference for common origin by blood. By whatever links cognates are united they express their kinship by citing their descent-names. Correspondingly, strangers who find they share a descent-name feel that they are kin. The descent-names have this high value because they originated with the first Lozi who lived with King Mboo. They symbolize the notion that kinship, relationship by blood as such, comes from the beginning of time, even though the Lozi can only remember their genealogical ties back for a very few generations. They give historic depth to the shallow genealogical system. Every descent-name is related to some stage of Lozi history: the Lozi names are those of the first inhabitants of the plain, those of 178 foreign tribes date to the absorption of these tribes in the nation. The villages which are the corporate groups of kindred are built on mounds which provide the only sites for homes in the plain. Certain of these mounds are known as those of the Lozi's distant forebears, and each Lozi descent-name is referred to an ancestral village on one of these mounds. The possession of a Lozi descent-name enables a man to point to his ancestral village, and claim to be a true Lozi, a true inhabitant of the plain, a descendant by blood of the original settlers related to the daughter of God, a kinsman of all Lozi.

612  
Kindreds And Ramples

619  
Tribe And Nation

621  
Community Structure

---

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